

Mortality Equations for CONUS

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2026-05-20

Data

We took the FIA mortality data subset, filtered out missing data (primarily crown ratio and heights). This left 4343197 observations.

The observations are distributed among states is show in Table 1.

Table 1: Mortality Observations by State

State	n
MN	396255
ME	327368
WI	321417
MI	298910
OR	204776
GA	176540
NY	170537
PA	152055
AL	141930
WA	137839
VA	136219
MO	135853
NC	124516
AR	112689
SC	112014
MS	111427
TN	109749
CA	105913
MT	95025
KY	88127
TX	85291

Table 1: Mortality Observations by State

State	n
CO	79722
WV	78684
NH	73331
ID	61960
OH	53553
VT	52214
FL	49165
LA	43621
IN	42858
OK	36910
IL	30733
MA	24706
UT	24542
IA	17511
AZ	16740
NM	15355
SD	13697
NJ	13336
MD	13040
WY	11708
CT	10842
KS	10777
NE	7360
ND	5496
RI	4712
DE	4444
NV	1730

Base Rate Mortality

Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky¹ made the point that any putative model should improve upon the *base rate*. In our case, the base rate is the average mortality rate for each species accounting for no other factors. We calculate this by taking the annualized mean mortality rate for each species in the data set.

The base rate estimates for 183 species are distributed as shown in Figure 1. Most base rate annual survival estimates are between 98 and 100%.

¹Kahneman D. and Tversky, A. (1973). On the Psychology of Prediction. *Psychology Review*. 80(4), 237-251. doi: 10.1037/h0034747

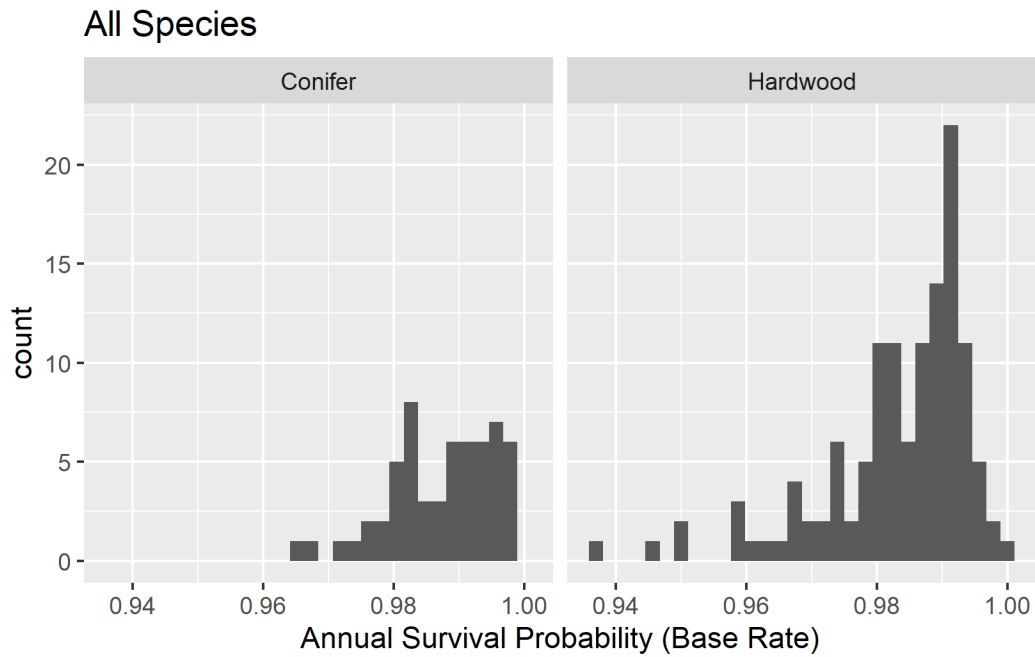


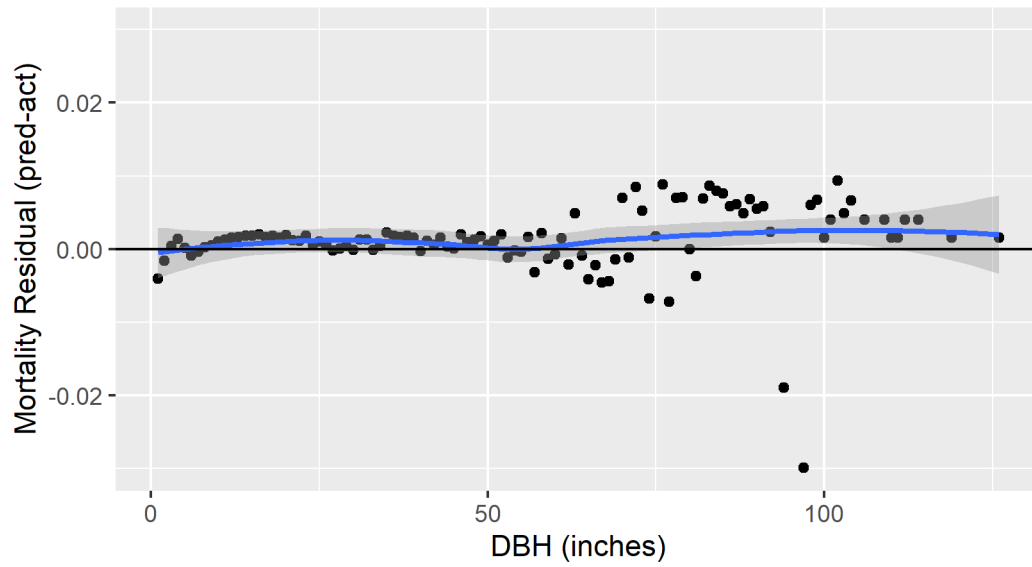
Figure 1

Base Rate Residuals

The following residual graphs show the average errors for all species over classes of possible explanatory variables.

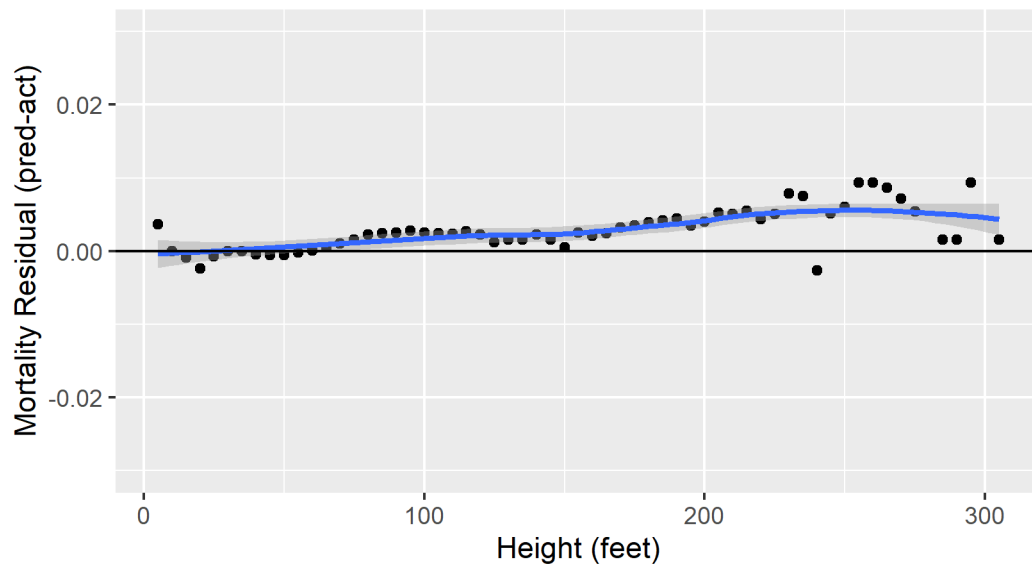
Mortality Residuals

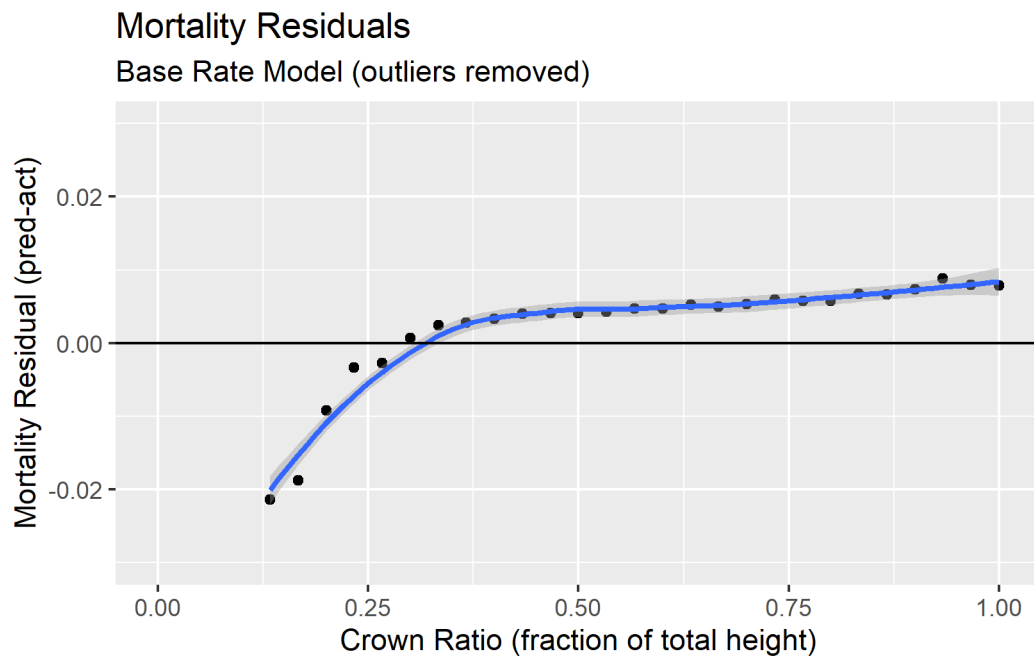
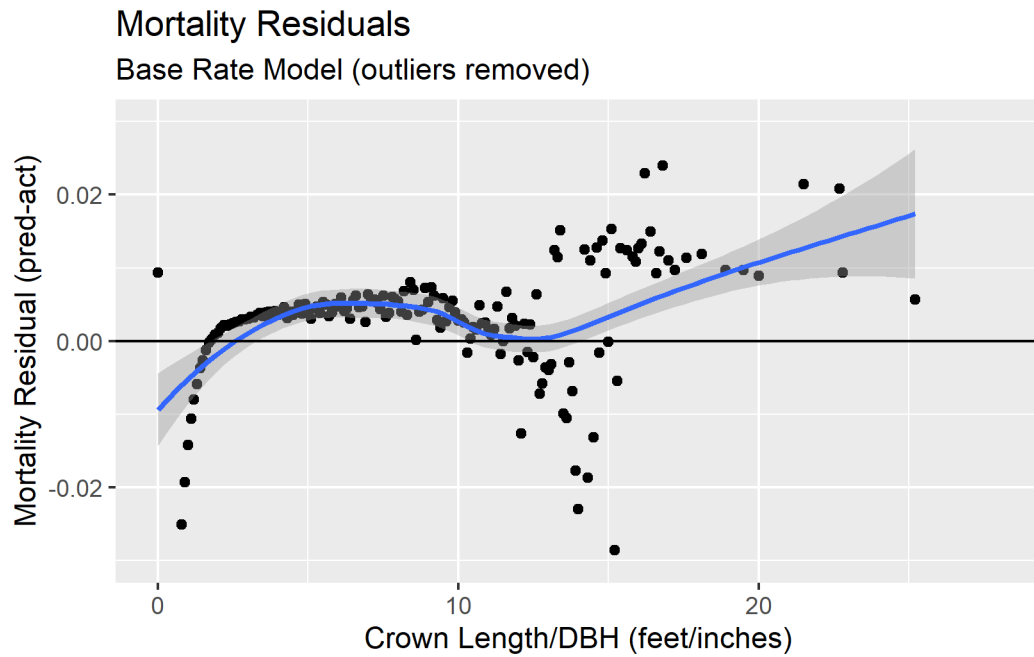
Base Rate Model (outliers removed)

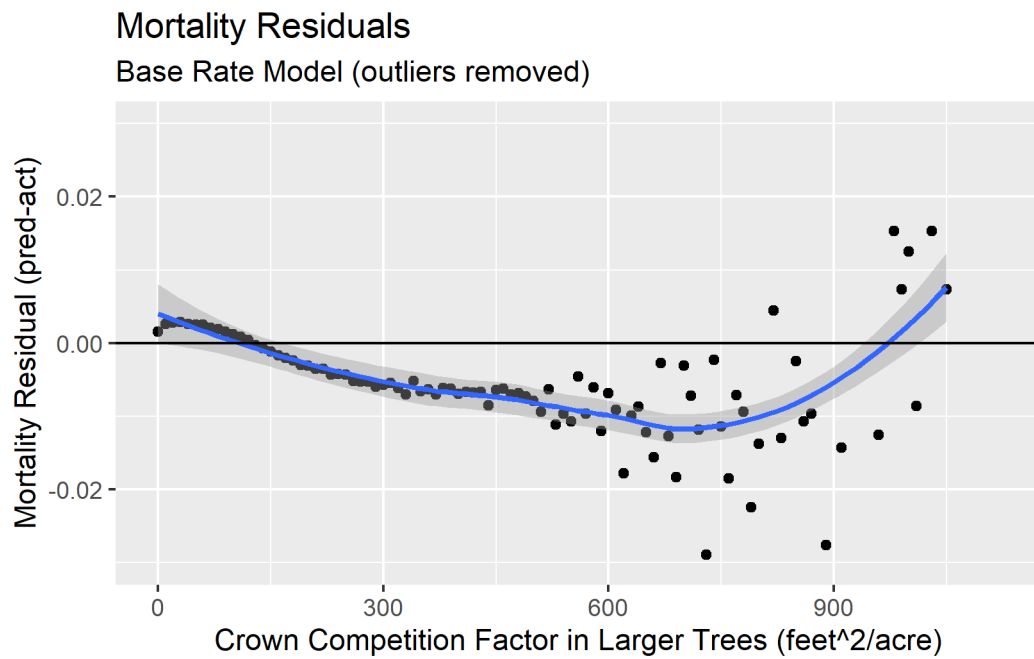
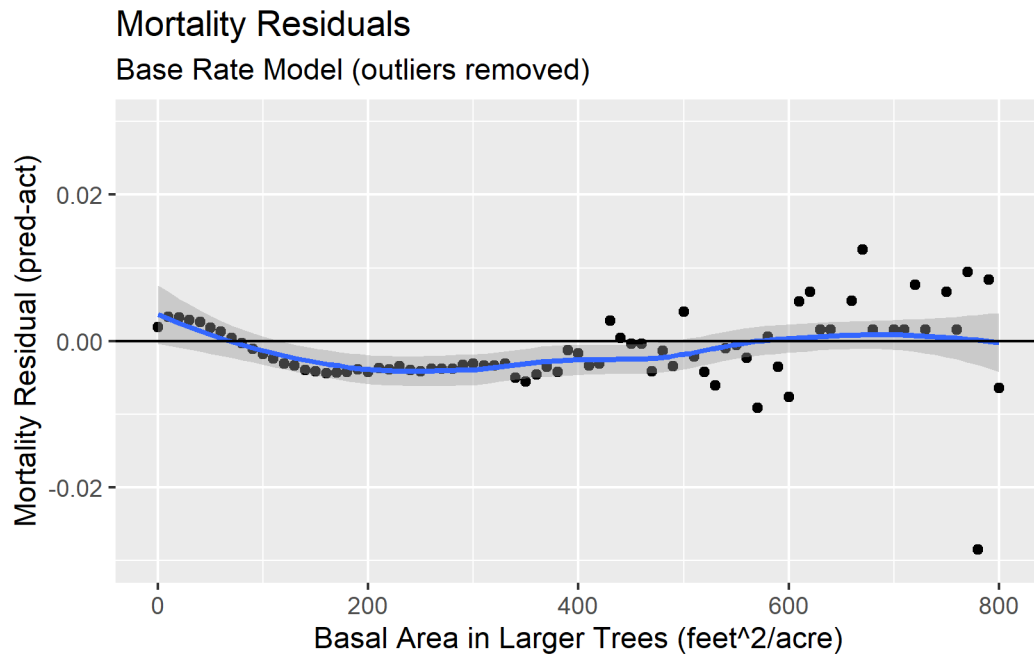


Mortality Residuals

Base Rate Model (outliers removed)

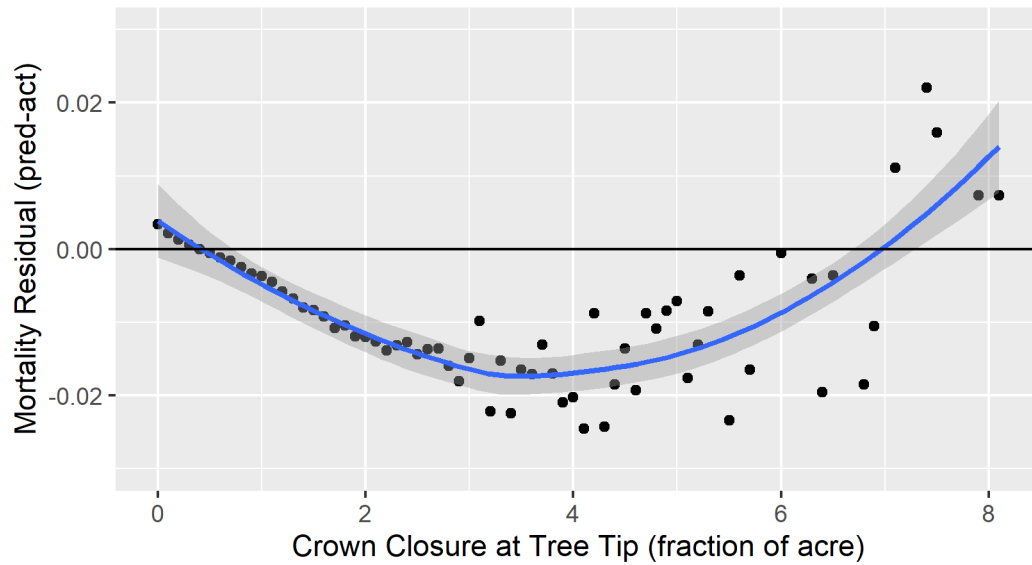






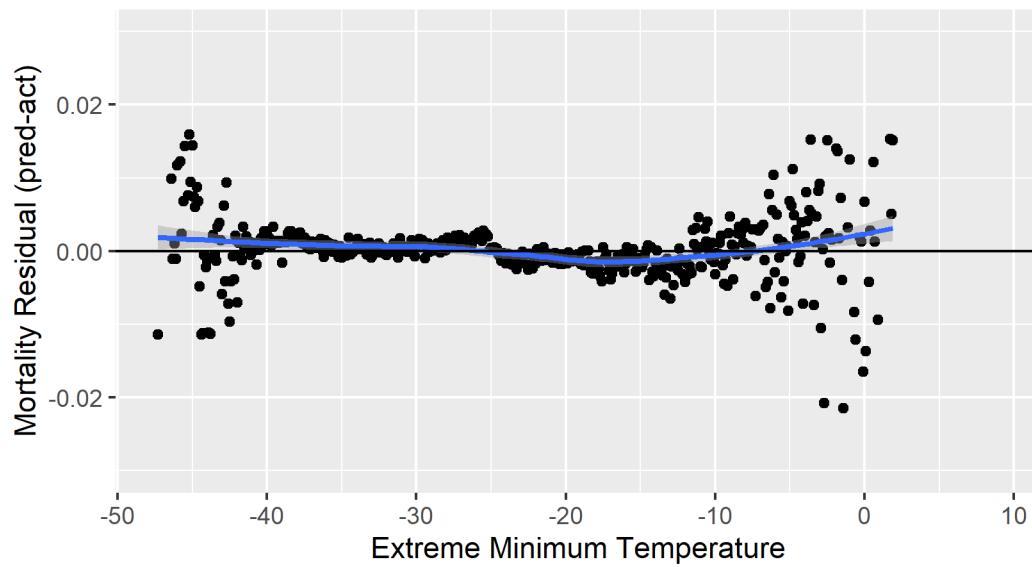
Mortality Residuals

Base Rate Model (outliers removed)



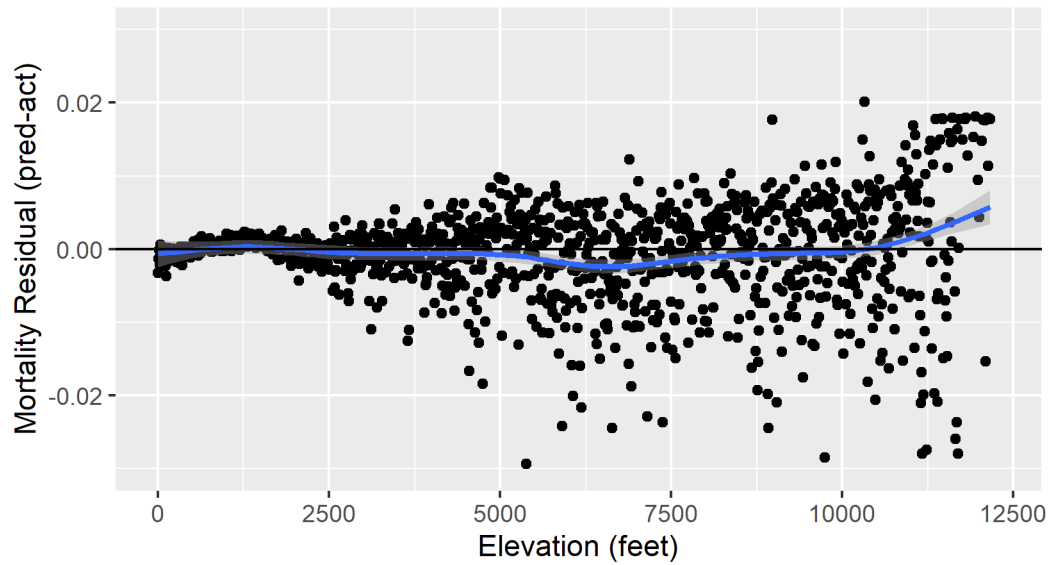
Mortality Residuals

Base Rate Model (outliers removed)



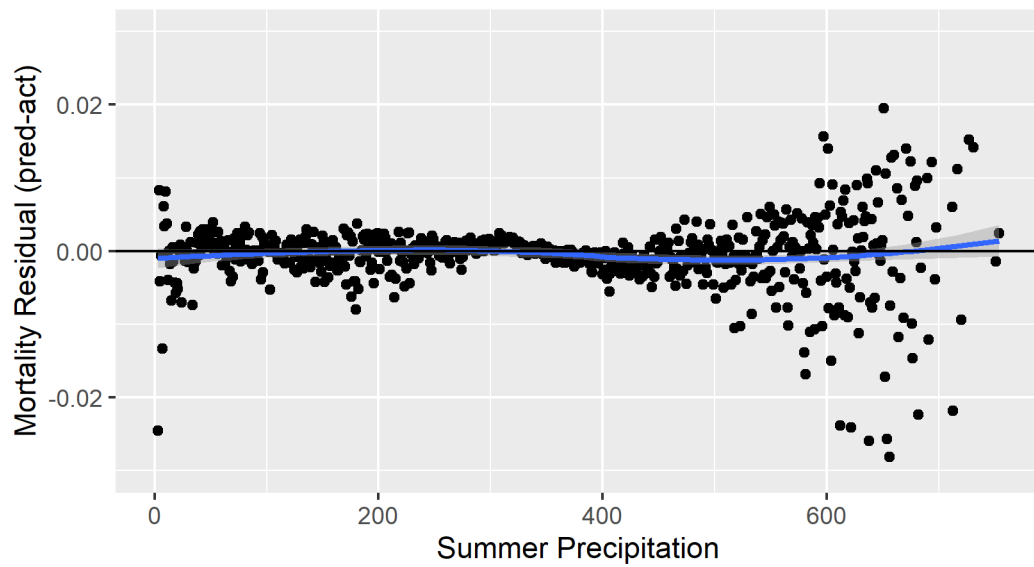
Mortality Residuals

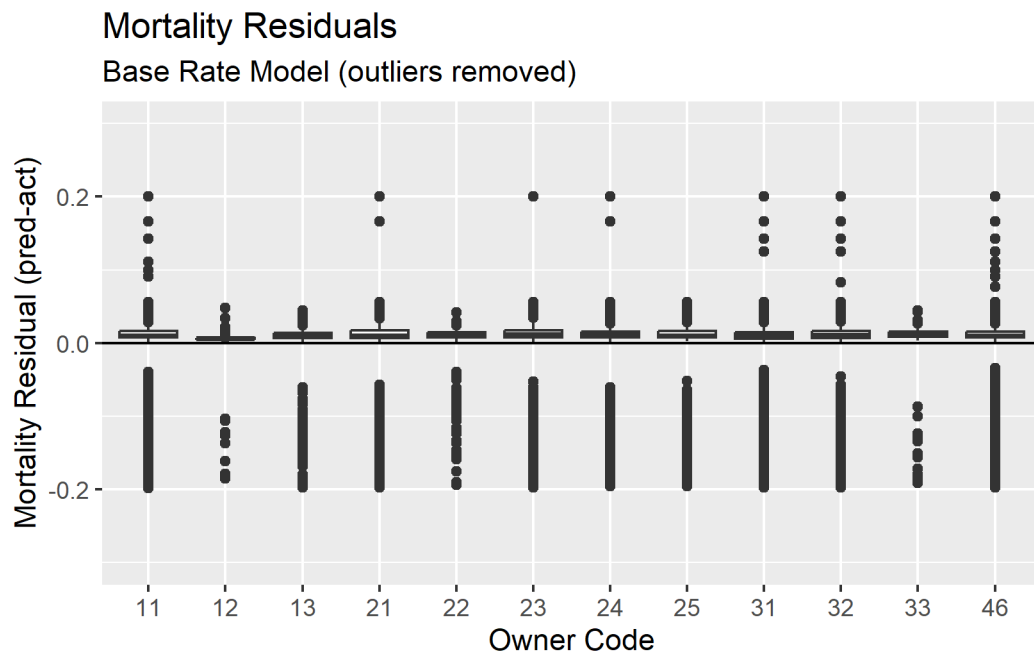
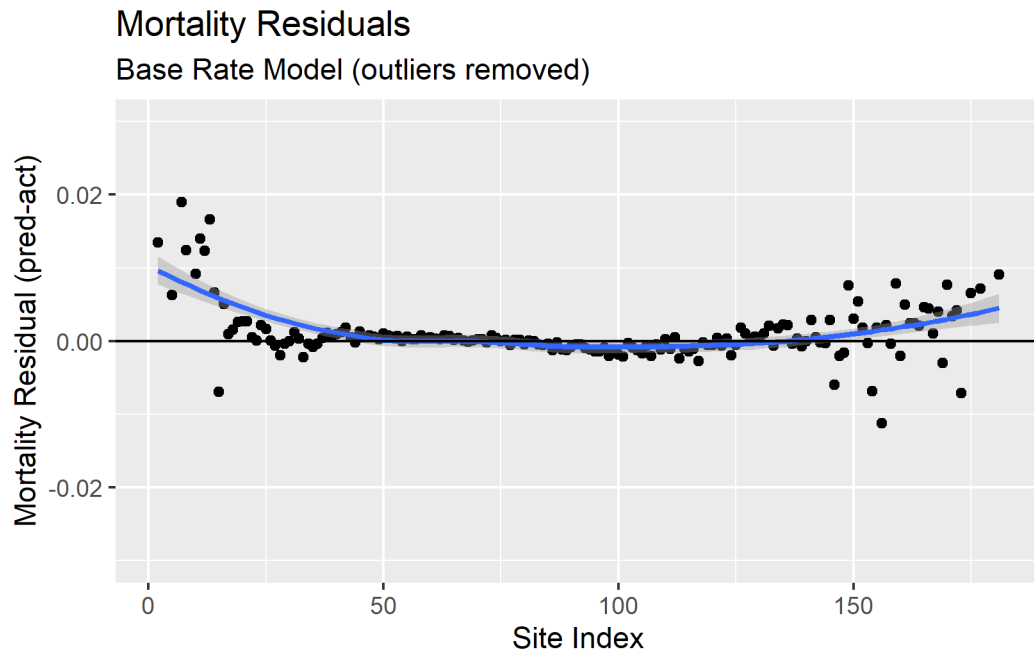
Base Rate Model (outliers removed)

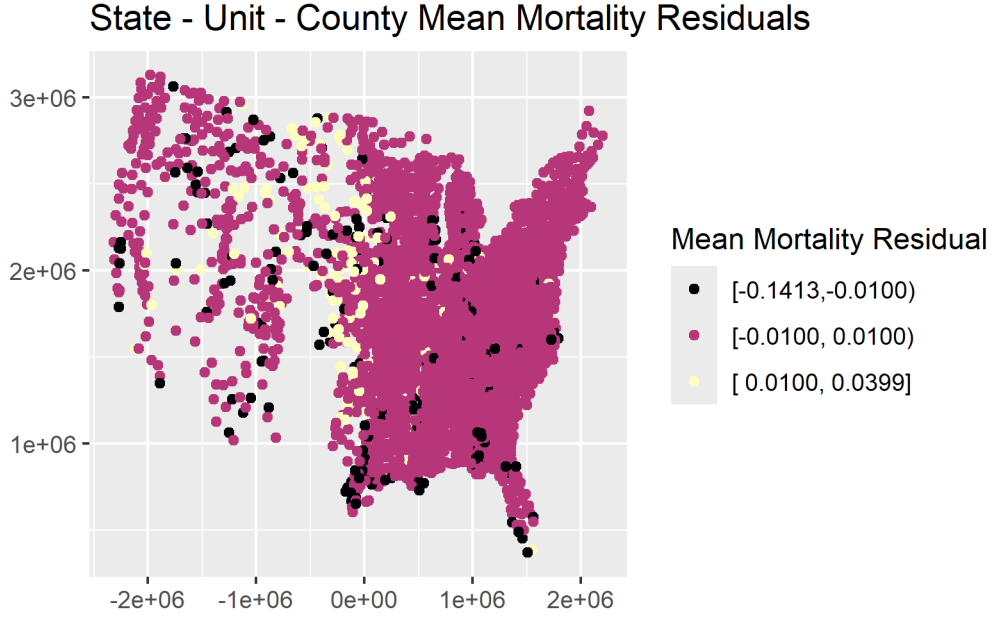


Mortality Residuals

Base Rate Model (outliers removed)







Proposed Model

The model we propose to explain more of the mortality variation over the base rate is a Gompit function:

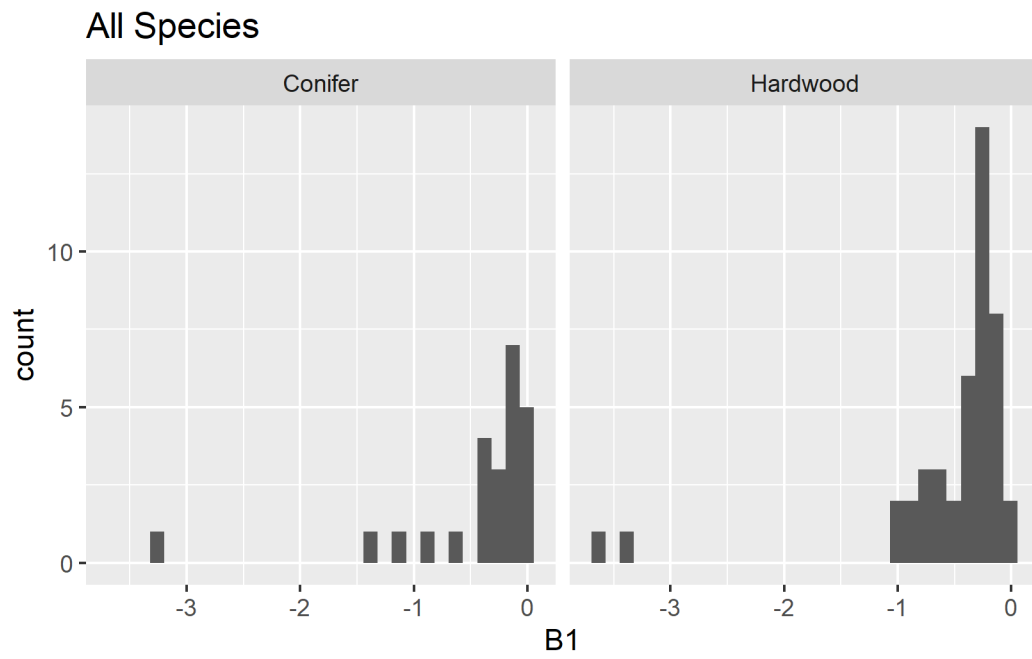
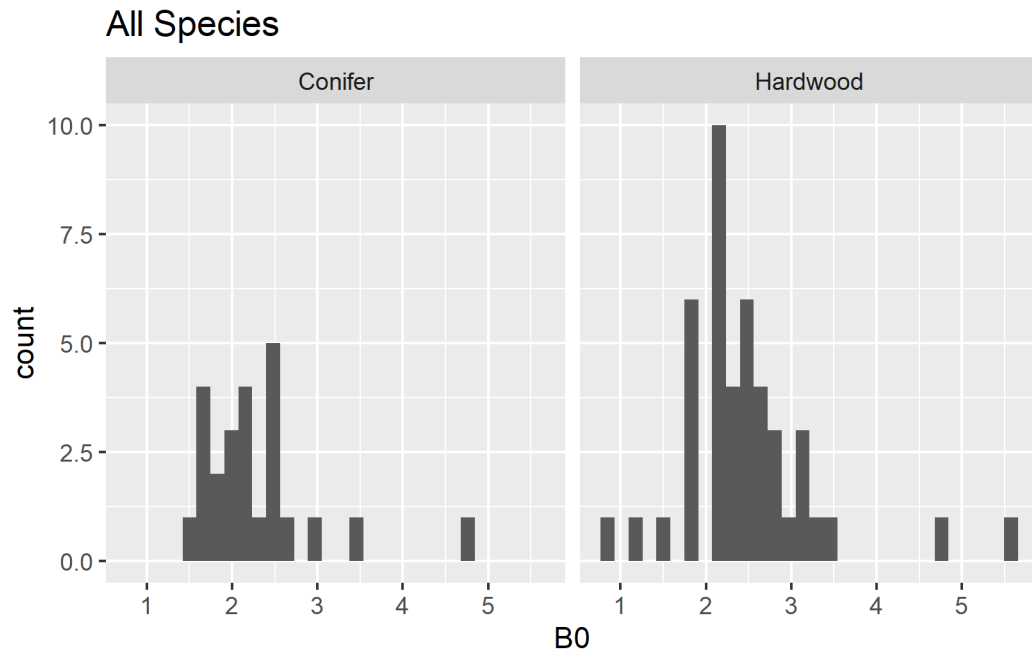
$$P_{surv} = 1 - e^{(-e^{(\beta_0 + \beta_1(cr + 0.01)^{\beta_2} + \beta_3 cch^{\beta_4}))})} \quad (1)$$

where:

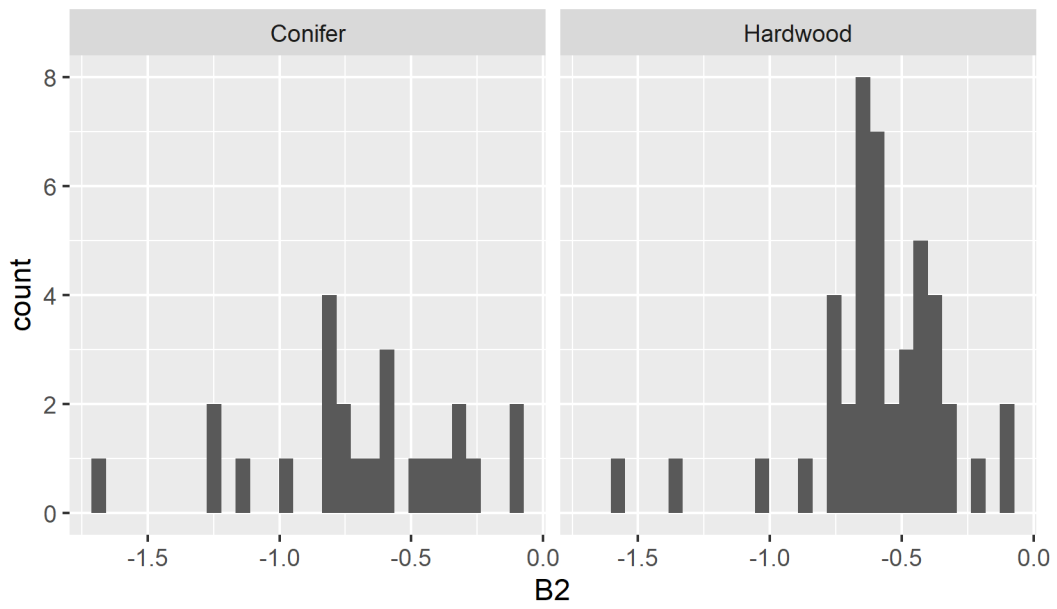
- P_{surv} : probability of survival
- cr : crown ratio
- cch : crown closure at tree tip

We used an integrative fitting approach to account for varying period lengths and we minimized the negative log-likelihood for each species separately.

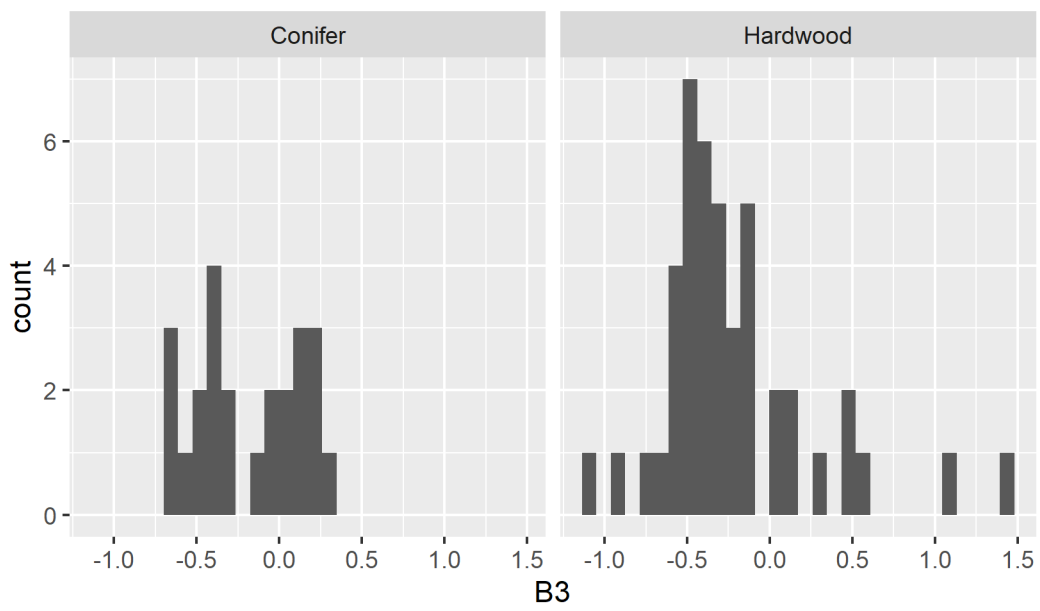
The distributions of the parameter estimates for all species are shown below.

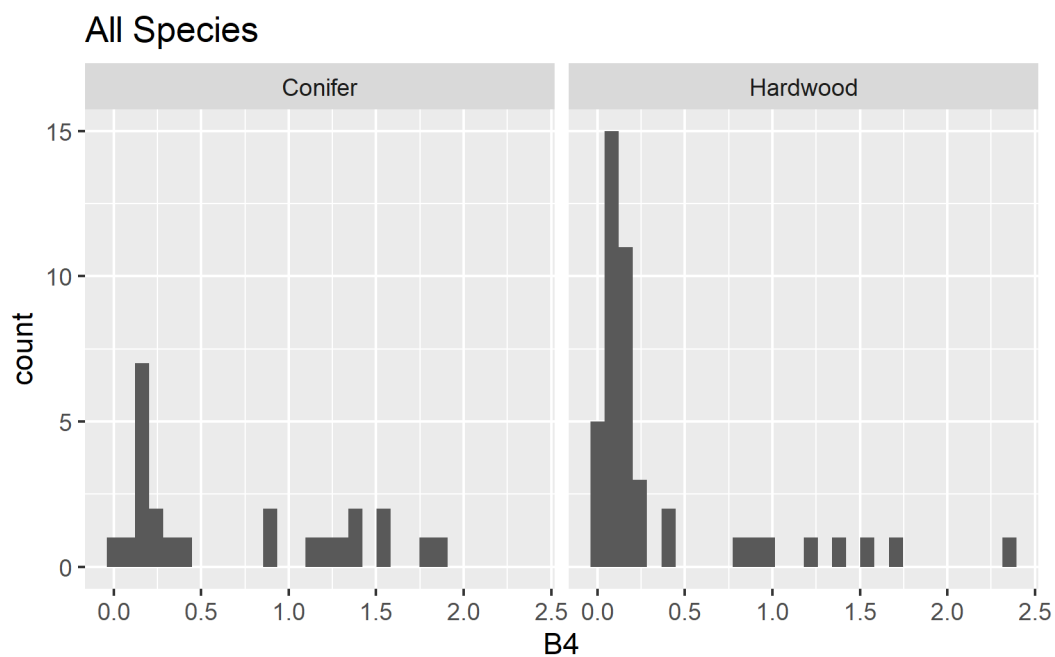


All Species



All Species





As Figure 2 shows, the majority of species' negative log likelihoods were reduced with the proposed model. Table 2 lists the species where there was a degradation in fit.

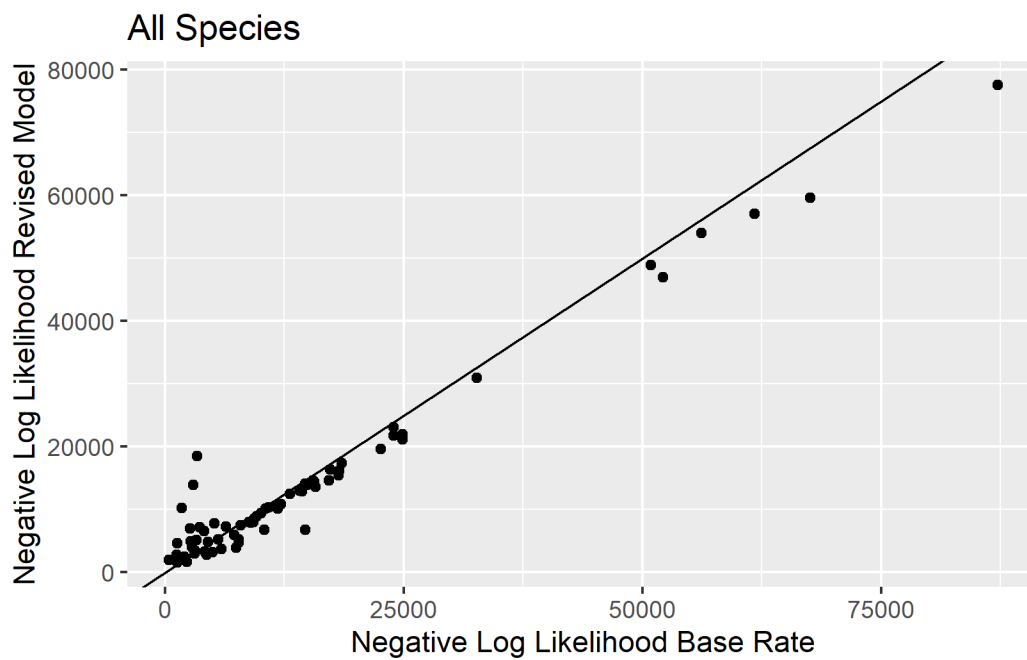


Figure 2

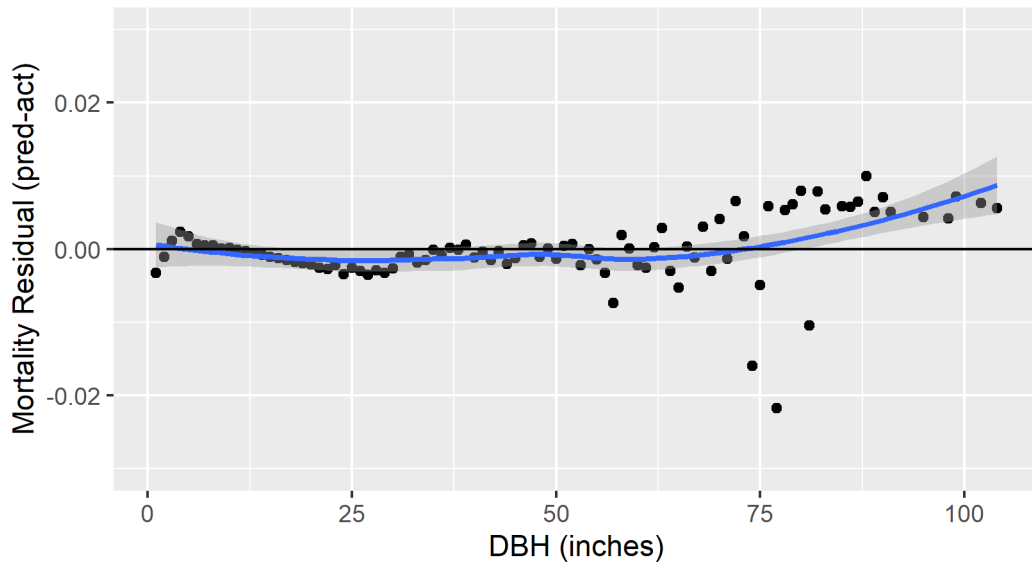
Table 2: Species with Poorer Performance than Base Rate

SPCD	Common Name	N
824	blackjack oak	11659
116	Jeffrey pine	11946
741	balsam poplar	22219
317	silver maple	21081
409	mockernut hickory	27266
809	northern pin oak	12850
211	redwood	6247
731	American sycamore	11341
823	bur oak	30552
407	shagbark hickory	14498
820	laurel oak	60176
951	American basswood	50501
462	hackberry	28814
313	boxelder maple	21439
242	western redcedar	15283
602	black walnut	27941
264	mountain hemlock	33459
653	sweetbay magnolia	42301

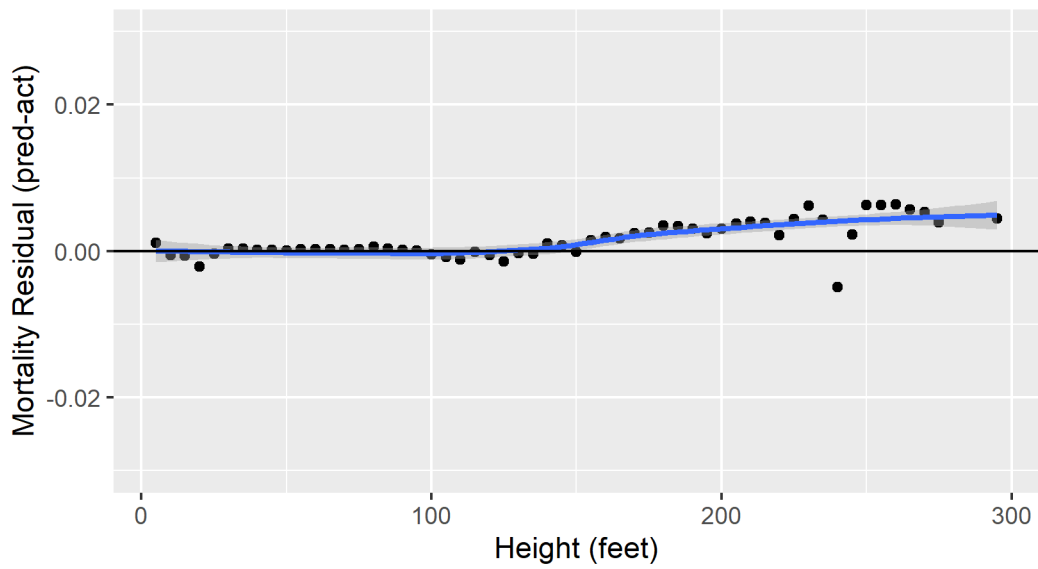
Proposed Model Residuals

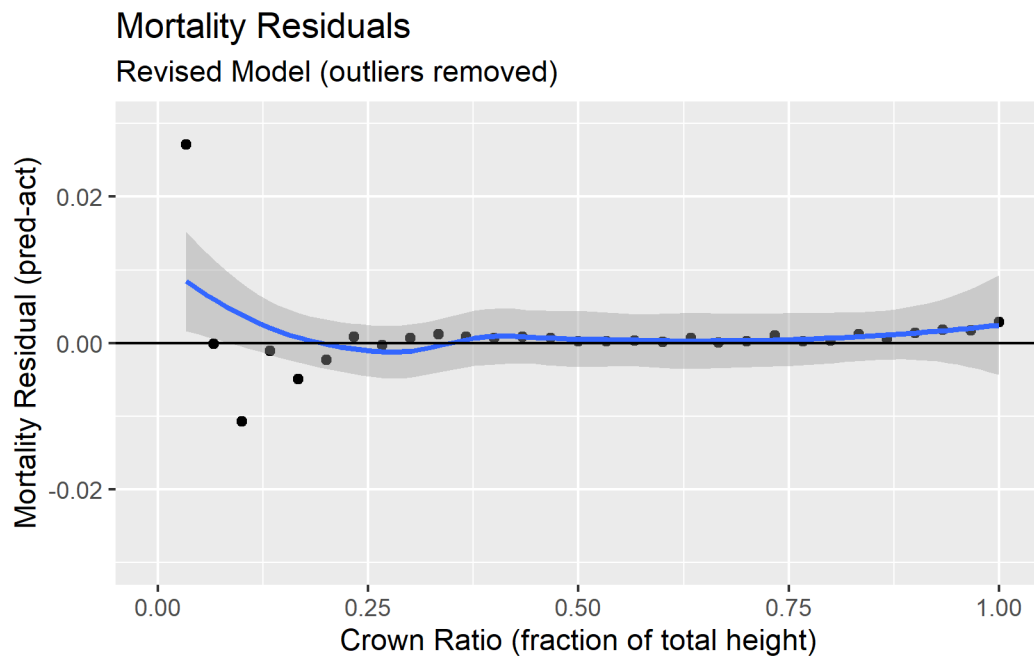
The following residual graphs show the average errors for all species where the fit improved over the base rate over classes of possible explanatory variables.

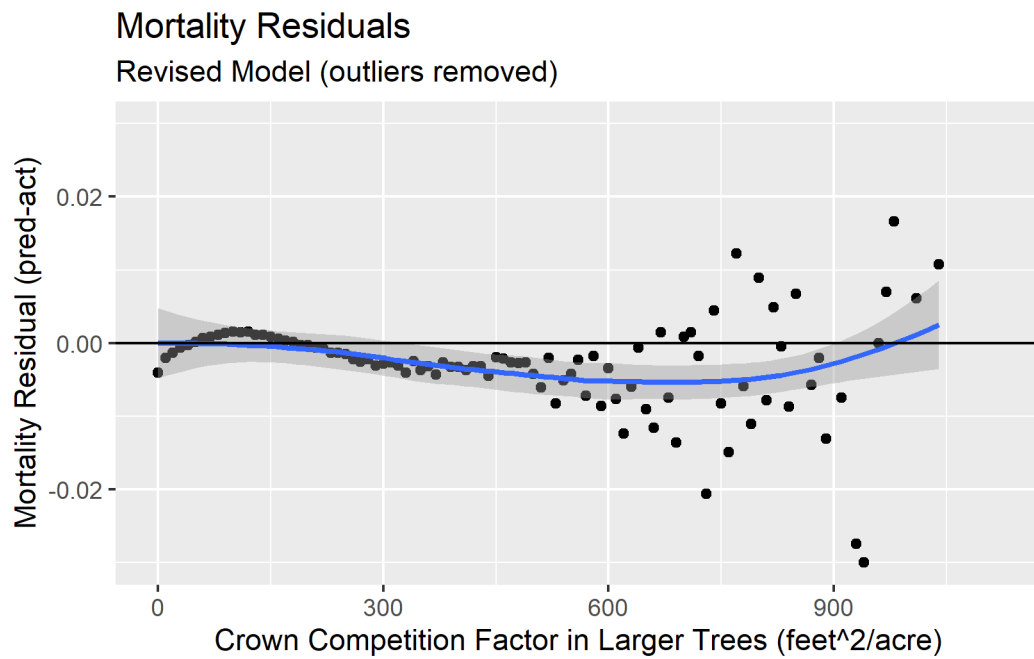
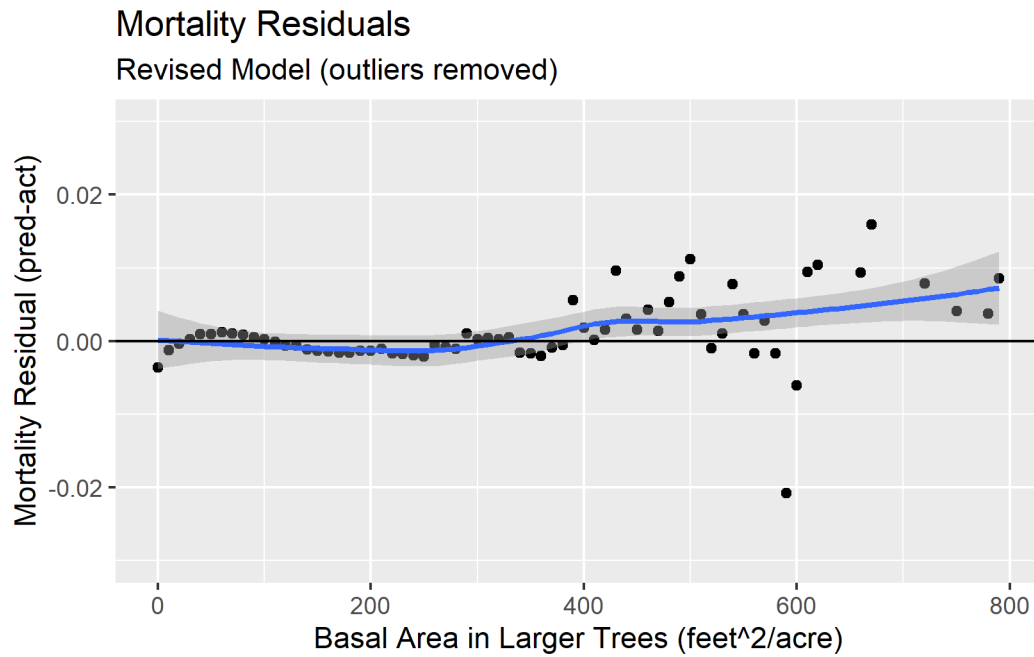
Mortality Residuals
Revised Model (outliers removed)

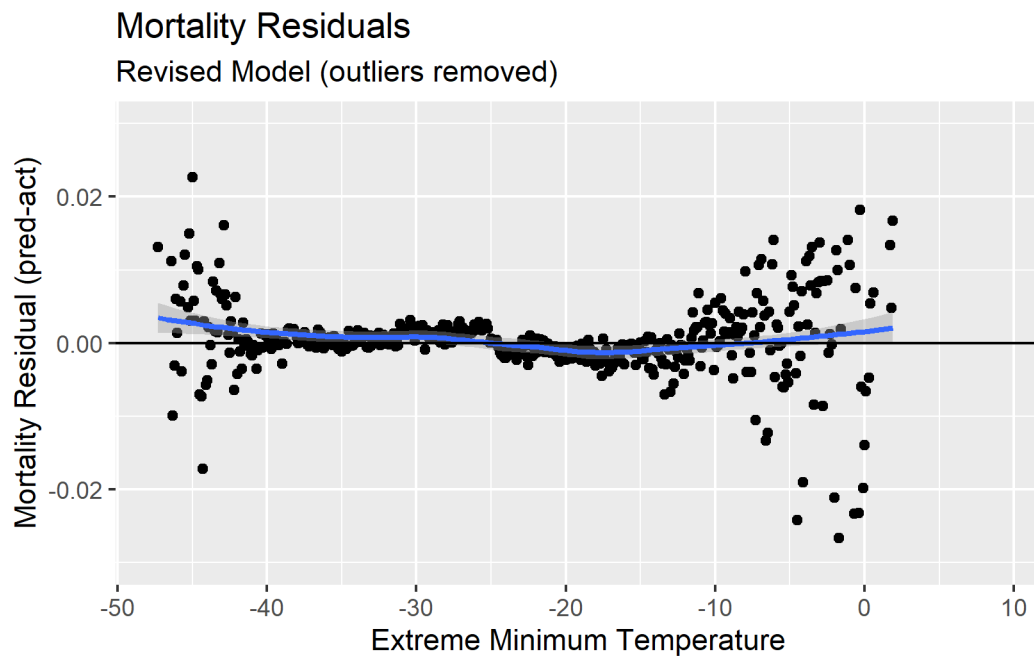


Mortality Residuals
Revised Model (outliers removed)

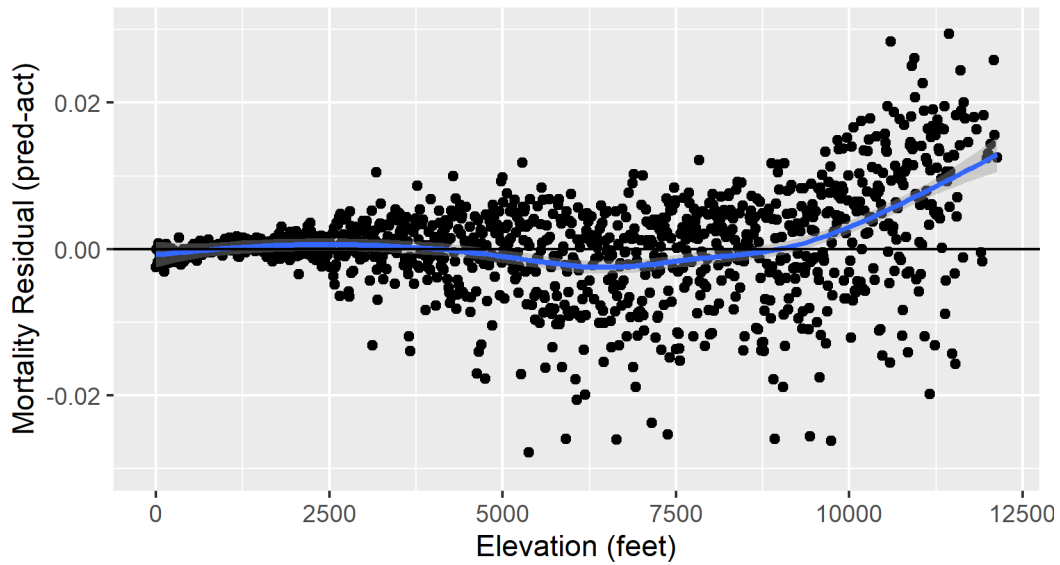




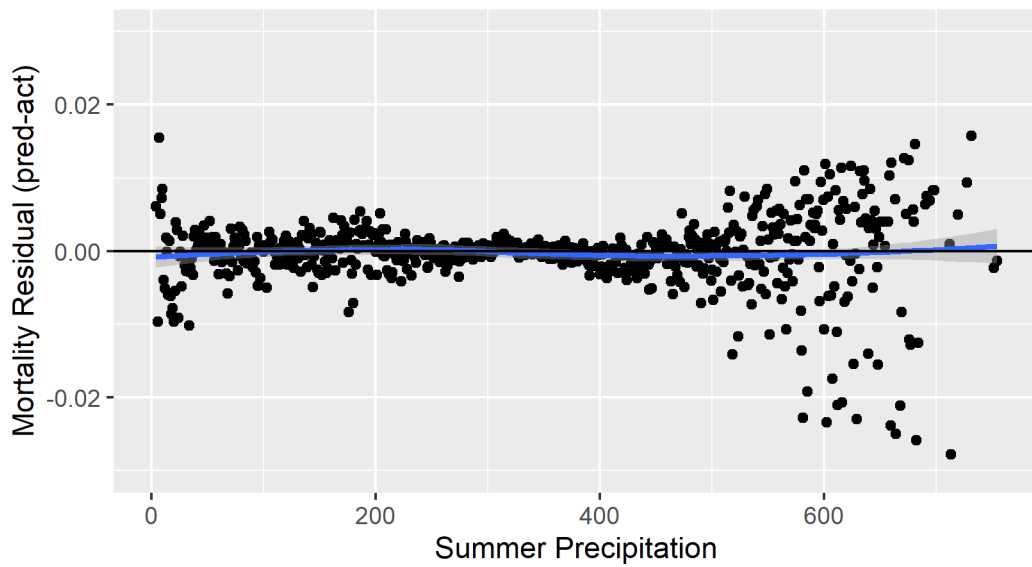


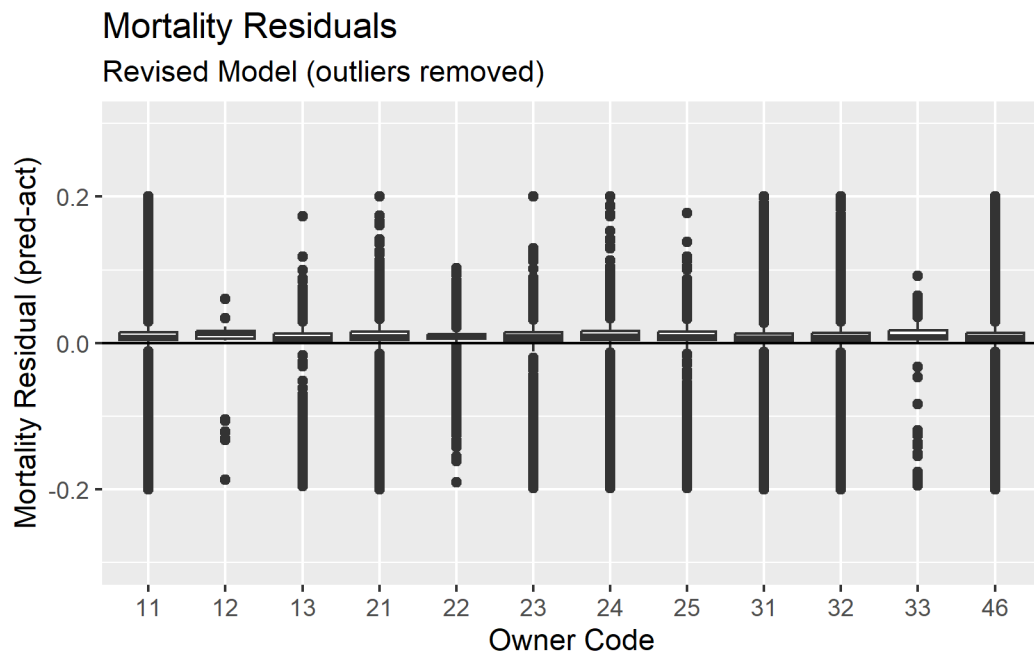
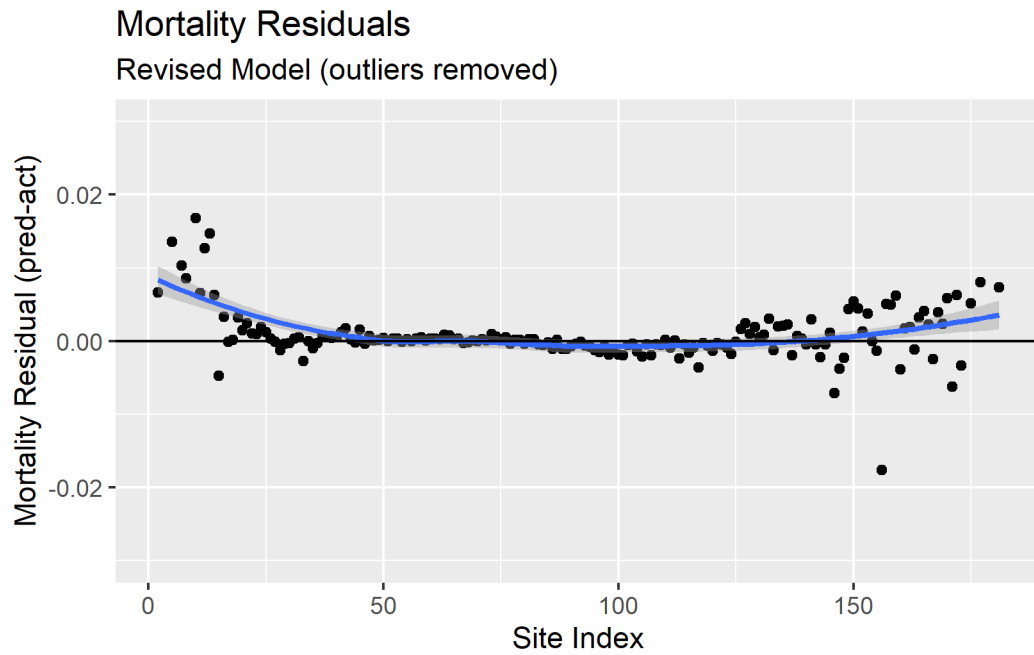


Mortality Residuals
Revised Model (outliers removed)



Mortality Residuals
Revised Model (outliers removed)





State - Unit - County Mean Mortality Residuals

